

How bad is AI to our environment?

Posted by u/jyiehs • 0 points • 10 comments

I am genuinely curious. I have asked people and searched about it but somehow I just don't get it. How is it bad for our environment? I understand the ethics of it when it comes to workplace and art, but other than that, I really don't know much about AI.

Comments

u/archpaw • 1 points • 2025-04-22 02:33 UTC

A lot of people talk about the water usage, which sounds like a lot, but is completely trivial compared to something like meat. As for the electricity, it's comparable to anything else that costs that much for electricity. I think it's mostly people just people who are against AI trying to talk about AI being bad in every way.

u/ManWhoClappedJesus • 1 points • 2025-04-22 02:26 UTC

People will always be the problem not the tool. Always remember that.

u/asdfredditusername • 2 points • 2025-04-22 02:17 UTC

Worse than mining Bitcoin.

u/PracticalAd313 • 1 points • 2025-04-22 02:13 UTC

I'm more worried about cryptocurrency than AI. AI at least has practical use unlike cryptocurrencies which basically use electricity and produce a lot of heat just to calculate meaningless numbers

u/Clean_Parsnip_1697 • 2 points • 2025-04-22 02:08 UTC

Seemingly much like a service which requires complex calculations or high usage it requires power (crypto) to where it can use the equivalent of small countries power usage and we aren't exactly green or nuclear.

u/pythonpoole • 2 points • 2025-04-22 02:07 UTC

The simplified answer is that LLM AIs (like ChatGPT) have to do a massive number of mathematical operations each time they generate a response. And this directly correlates with the amount of electricity used. In other words, every time you ask an AI to respond to you, that requires a large amount of electricity to be used, which in turn may be harmful to the environment depending on how that electricity is being generated. If the electricity is sourced from green/renewable sources (e.g. solar, wind, hydro, etc.) then the environmental impact is a lot lower. If it comes from other sources (like coal, oil, gas, etc.) then there may be a much greater environmental impact.

u/PracticalAd313 • 2 points • 2025-04-22 02:11 UTC

Yeah, but on the other hand it would require even more electricity to make all the work LLM does if people did it manually

u/pythonpoole • 2 points • 2025-04-22 02:34 UTC

The thing is that LLMs are being used for all sorts of tasks that humans weren't previously being used for (and for tasks that would simply never be performed by humans). So, at least in those cases, LLMs are increasing the total energy use, not helping to reduce it in any way.

For instance, it used to be the case that search engines would use more conventional (non-LLM) algorithms to generate search results which were a lot less power consuming, but now many search engines will default to also running your search query through an LLM AI which uses a lot more power.

So, the end result is that search queries now use a lot more electricity than they used to in the past. And it's not as if the search engine companies have fired tons of workers to offset the increases in energy use, ultimately the total power usage for these companies has gone way up.

u/thatthingthatitis • 2 points • 2025-04-22 02:05 UTC

The environmental impact is primarily in power and water consumption. GPT-3 consumed like a half-million gallons of water to train. It takes terawatts of power to run AI services. It's a massive environmental impact. So it is useful, but it's also a massive environmental impact.

u/anactualspacecadet • 0 points • 2025-04-22 02:03 UTC

Its not bad for the environment, people are bad for the environment.